MANUAL QA · ESTIMATOR · UPDATED SEPTEMBER 2026

Estimator QA Walkthrough

The full run from scope to project, updated for pricing by role and level. Prices now come from each line's own rate, people carry work keys, and catalog work is scheduled by who does it. Follow the steps in order, since each one sets up the next.

SETTINGS & TEAM · ESTIMATOR · ZOHO CRM · PBS BILLING

WHAT CHANGED SINCE THE LAST WALKTHROUGH

- **Hourly rates by role and level.** IT, Creative, Project Manager, QA Tester and Project Coordinator each have a Level 1 and a Level 2 rate. Only an admin can edit them, in Settings.
- **New catalog.** Every task shows who does it, at what level, and at what rate. Some tasks also carry a "Things to consider" note.
- **Price per line.** Each line keeps the rate it was added at, so changing a rate never reprices an estimate by itself. Updating an estimate to today's rates is a deliberate, previewed step.
- **Work keys.** An admin gives people keys like "IT Level 2". Start project assigns by key first and uses skill stars only to break ties.
- **Timeline by role.** Creative catalog work now lands in the Design phase and QA work in the QA phase, instead of everything sitting in Development.

BEFORE YOU START

- Sign in as an **admin**. Steps 1–4 edit rates and work keys, which only admins can change. Keep a **manager** and a **member** login handy for the permission checks.
- Use a **test client** in Zoho. From step 10 on you write to the real CRM, and step 13 writes to real billing, which has no delete.
- Name everything you create **MY TEST ...**. On **real estimates**, only look. If a dialog offers to change one, press **Cancel**.
- Undo your changes as you go. The rates and keys you touch are live for the whole team, and the clean-up list at the end covers everything.

Part 1 — Rates and work keys

About ten minutes. These are the settings the rest of the run prices and assigns from.

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01 **Read the rate table** ● SETTINGS NEW

Settings → **Workspace** → **Hourly rates**.

> EXPECT Five roles, each with a Level 1 and a Level 2 rate: IT `100 / 120`, Creative `100 / 130`, Project Manager `80 / 100`, QA Tester `80 / 120`, Project Coordinator `0 / 0`. The $0 is intentional, because coordination isn't billed.
>
> A note under the table says each estimate line keeps the rate it was added at.

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02 **Try to save bad rates** ● SETTINGS NEW

Set IT Level 2 to `90`, which is below its Level 1. Then try `-5`, `abc`, `10.555` and `10001`. Finish with **Reset**.

> EXPECT "Level 2 can't be below Level 1" appears on that cell and **Save** is disabled. Each bad value is refused. Reset puts back the saved values without saving anything.

03 Check who can see rates ● SETTINGS NEW

Open Settings as a **manager**, then as a **member** (use a private window).

> EXPECT **Manager:** the rates show as plain text, with no fields and no Save button, plus the line "Only admins can change rates."
>
> **Member:** there's no Workspace tab and no rates anywhere.

04 Give a teammate a work key ● TEAM NEW

Team → click the **star** button on a colleague's row. Under **Work keys**, set IT to **L1**, then QA Tester to **L1**, clicking quickly. Close the dialog. **Leave these keys on until step 14.**

> EXPECT Their row reads "IT L1 · QA Tester L1" under their email, and nothing you clicked goes missing.
>
> Open the same dialog as a **manager**: the keys show as text with "Only admins can change work keys." and no buttons.

Part 2 — The run

About thirty minutes. Every amount should trace back to **hours × that line's own rate**, not a flat rate.

05 Create the estimate ● ESTIMATOR

Estimator → **New estimate**. Title it **MY TEST – pricing**, choose **WordPress**, and give it a client name. Delete the empty starter row.

> EXPECT It opens straight into the editor on **Line items**.

06 Scope from the new catalog ESTIMATOR CHANGED

Browse catalog. Click the **Creative** chip, then **Level 2**, then clear both. Search **Industry Selector**, tick it, and add it. Then add any one **Creative** task and any one **QA Tester** task.

> EXPECT Every task shows its role and level ("IT · Level 2") and its current rate ("$120/h"). Some show an amber **Things to consider** note. The chips filter the list, and the category counts follow.
>
> The Industry Selector line reads "... · IT L2 · $120/h", **8 h**, and **$960**.

07 Check the pricing ESTIMATOR NEW

Look at the header. Then open one line's details and change its **Role** to another role, check the price, and change it back. Finally open the **Adjust** tab.

> EXPECT Because the lines have different rates, the header shows the total with "avg $.../h". Each line's price is its hours × its rate, and the lines add up to the header.
>
> Changing the role changes that one line's rate and price and nothing else. On Adjust, the **Hourly rates** card says "Matches today's rates."

08 See the timeline by role ESTIMATOR NEW

Open the **Scope & risk** tab and look at the timeline. Then change the Creative line's Role to **IT**, look again, and change it back to Creative.

> EXPECT Three bars in order: **Design & UX** (the Creative task), **Development** (Industry Selector) and **QA & Testing** (the QA task).
>
> When the Creative line becomes IT, the Design bar disappears and Development grows by the same hours. The total hours in the header never change.

09 Attach the client and products

ESTIMATOR ZOHO CRM

Setup tab → **Find in Zoho** on the Client field, then pick a company and a contact. Then **Add from Zoho** and pick two or three products.

> EXPECT Each product gets a share of the hours and a price. The prices add up to *exactly* the header total, and nothing is typed by hand.

10 Check the documents, then send to Zoho

ESTIMATOR ZOHO CRM

Review tab → download the **PDF** and **Excel**. Then **Send to Zoho**, and read the preview before confirming: the stage, the amount, the hours and each product row.

> EXPECT The PDF and Excel show a price on every line, and the lines add up to the total. **No hourly rate, role or level appears anywhere**, because those are internal.
>
> The deal lands on **Discovery** with the PDF attached. In Zoho, the deal's Amount matches the estimate's header total.

11 Walk it up the pipeline

ESTIMATOR ZOHO CRM

Estimator list → **Stages**. Drag the card by its handle, or use the ⇄ menu on it, through Negotiation → Proposal Sent → Verbal Yes.

> EXPECT The card moves at once, and the deal's stage in Zoho changes to match. Refresh Zoho each time to confirm.

12 Win the deal

ESTIMATOR ZOHO CRM

Move the card to **Closed Won**.

> EXPECT The estimate's status flips to **Approved** on its own, and **Create PO** and **Start project** both appear.

13 Raise the purchase order

ESTIMATOR · PBS BILLING

Create PO. Check the billing client, the template and the project dates, then confirm.

> EXPECT The dates come from the timeline in step 8, so the end date is the launch date that timeline showed, including the Design phase.
>
> A PO number appears on the card and in the header. It can't be undone, because PBS has no delete.

14 Start the project

ESTIMATOR · CHANGED

Start project → choose a strategy → **Review schedule**. Read who gets each task and why, then **Confirm & create**.

> EXPECT **Industry Selector** is IT Level 2, and your teammate only holds IT Level 1, so it shows "Nobody holds IT Level 2 — assign manually". It is not handed to them.
>
> The **QA task** goes to your teammate, with "QA Tester L1" in the reason. The **Creative task** is left for a human ("assign manually"), as design work always was, because nobody holds a Creative key yet.
>
> The project gets **Design & UX / Development / QA & Testing** sprints, each task sits in its role's sprint, and the **backlog is empty**.

15 Change a rate after the fact

SETTINGS · ESTIMATOR · NEW

Settings → set IT Level 2 to `150` and save. Open MY TEST – pricing → **Adjust**. Press **Update to current rates** and confirm. Then **set IT Level 2 back to 120**.

> EXPECT Before you press anything, the price hasn't moved. The card says "At today's rates this estimate would be … (+$240)". The dialog shows the old → new total, and afterwards Industry Selector costs $1,200.
>
> On the Setup tab, the CRM amount now shows in amber because Zoho still has the old figure. Nothing changes in Zoho until someone sends again.

Then try to break it

These are the guards. Each one should stop you and say why.

Open a real estimate (e.g. Test Estimate - 1 - Patrick) after this update	→ It still shows $70,800. Adjust offers "Update to current rates" (−$2,580). Press Cancel
Save a Level 2 rate below its Level 1	→ Save is disabled and the cell says why
Change a rate, then reopen an estimate made earlier	→ Its price is unchanged until someone presses Update to current rates
Open a colleague's work keys as a manager or member	→ Read-only, with no buttons. Only admins can set keys
A Level 2 task when only Level 1 people hold that key	→ Left unassigned with "Nobody holds … Level 2", never given to a junior
Sync schedule on a project after changing a line's role	→ Tasks already in a sprint stay put. Only new tasks go to their role's sprint
Click Create PO on an estimate that already has one	→ The button is gone and the PO number shows instead
Set the PO's end date before its start date	→ The confirm button is disabled and says why
Send to Zoho again after sales moved the deal past Discovery	→ The stage stays where sales put it, while the PDF and pricing still go up
Send the same unchanged estimate to Zoho twice	→ The PDF isn't attached a second time
Reject an estimate, then move its deal to Closed Won	→ It stays rejected. The stage moves, the status doesn't

Also check

Quick passes once the run above is clean.

On a phone or a narrow window	→ The rates table, the work-keys dialog and the timeline all fit with no sideways page scroll. The Gantt scrolls inside its own box
A catalog estimate with only IT tasks	→ One Development bar, exactly as before this update
Approve a teammate's time off over a task from this project	→ Cover suggestions show the key that qualifies them (e.g. "QA Tester L1")
Sign in as a member or viewer	→ No Estimator in the sidebar, and no rates in Settings

CLEAN UP WHEN YOU'RE DONE

- Settings → Hourly rates are back to **100/120 · 100/130 · 80/100 · 80/120 · 0/0**.
- Team → your teammate's work keys are set back to **None**.
- Delete the **MY TEST** project and estimates. The Zoho deal and the PBS PO stay behind, and need tidying by hand in those systems.

Found something? Note the step number, what you expected, and what you saw. If Zoho or PBS is involved, screenshot both sides together. Anything touching Zoho or PBS is a real write, so flag it rather than retrying.